CHAPTER XI

The Tenderness of Defeat

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"We imagine that knowing the truth will bring us closer to another person. Sometimes it only reveals the distance we have been crossing alone. Beside us, someone grieves a life we never entered; within us, another life quietly ends, though it had existed only in hope. We remain close enough to hear each other breathe, wondering what comfort we can offer while concealing why we need it ourselves."

January passed without offering Utkarsh anything particularly worth remembering.

February followed much the same way.

There were classes, unfinished notes, examinations to prepare for, and the familiar uncertainty of whether Sanondita would appear at coaching the following morning. Her attendance remained irregular. Some days she came; on others, the place beside him remained empty. Utkarsh himself had begun attending less frequently, though he could not have said precisely when the habit had developed.

Nothing had happened between them that might have justified calling those months unhappy.

That was perhaps what made them so difficult to describe.

There had been no quarrel, no awkward confession, no deliberate withdrawal. Whenever they met, they spoke much as they always had. There were questions about lessons, complaints

about difficult problems, and occasional conversations that wandered beyond their purpose. Sometimes she laughed. Sometimes she was preoccupied. Sometimes she had things to tell him, and sometimes she did not.

Life had continued in the unremarkable manner of things that had never promised to become extraordinary.

Utkarsh had grown accustomed to it.

Or had believed he had.

He had become accustomed to those months, or told himself he had. The distinction had not seemed important until that morning.

By the eleventh of March, a year and four days had passed since he had first seen Sanondita.

He did not think of the anniversary when he entered the classroom on the morning of the eleventh.

There was no reason he should have.

He had come to attend a lesson.

And she was there.

For a moment, that alone was enough to make the morning feel better than it had before he entered.

Then he noticed her.

Sanondita was sitting with her head resting against her folded arms on the desk. Her face was turned slightly away, and a few strands of hair had fallen untidily across her cheek.

Utkarsh slowed beside the seat.

She suffered from migraines. He knew that much. There had been occasions when a headache had made her quieter than usual, when the noise of the classroom seemed to trouble her, when she had looked tired even before the lesson began.

Perhaps it was another of those mornings.

He sat beside her and arranged his belongings without making unnecessary noise.

For a little while, he left her alone.

But something about her stillness troubled him.

It was not simply that her head was lowered. He had seen her tired before. It was the absence of those small, familiar movements through which he had come to recognise her. She did not adjust her hair. She did not straighten herself when someone passed. She seemed almost indifferent to the disorder of a few loose strands that, on another morning, she would have brushed away without thinking.

He wondered whether he was noticing too much again.

He had become rather skilled at that.

Still, he turned towards her.

“Sanondita, is everything okay?”

She lifted her head.

For a moment, he saw her face properly. Her hair had become slightly dishevelled where it had rested against her arms. She gave him a small nod.

Yes.

That was all.

He watched her for another second.

It was an answer, certainly. But it did not seem to belong to the question he had asked.

She lowered her head again.

Utkarsh looked towards the front of the classroom.

He could have left it there. Perhaps he should have. But he had known her long enough to recognise when her quietness was different from the ordinary quietness of a difficult morning.

He leaned a little towards her.

"Did Aunty scold you?"

She moved her head.

No.

He waited.

"Your sister?"

Again, no.

He looked at her, uncertain what to ask next.

There were other possibilities, of course. A disagreement at home. Some trouble with her students. A worry she did not wish to discuss. He knew enough about her life to imagine several reasons for unhappiness and too little to choose between them.

Then a different possibility occurred to him.

It was so sudden, and so strangely familiar, that he scarcely understood why he was giving it words.

"Breakup?"

She nodded.

Yes.

For a fraction of a moment, he remained perfectly still.

The next question came before he could decide whether he wanted to ask it.

"Nayan?"

She said yes.

And lowered her head again.

Utkarsh did not move.

The teacher was speaking at the front of the room. Someone nearby turned a page. A pen fell against a desk and was picked up again.

The morning continued.

He looked towards the board, though he could no longer have said what was written there.

Nayan.

So it had been Nayan.

He had asked the question himself. He had heard the answer. There was no misunderstanding to correct, no photograph to examine, no conversation to remember differently until it offered him some more comfortable possibility.

He had been right.

The possibility he had carried through all those months had been real. He still did not know when it had begun.

His pen was still poised above the page. He lowered it until the point touched the paper, but no number came.

Nayan.

He had said the name so softly. It had taken almost nothing to ask, and now he could not return to the moment before it.

Of all the names she might have spoken, of all the possibilities that might have explained her sadness, it had been the one name he had spent months trying to make ordinary.

He looked at Sanondita.

Her head remained lowered. A few strands of hair had fallen across her cheek, and she made no attempt to move them. He wondered whether her eyes were closed, whether she was listening to the lesson, whether she was remembering something that had happened between herself and Nayan.

He stopped himself there.

He did not want to imagine it.

The teacher wrote something on the board. Utkarsh looked towards it, watching the chalk move without following what was being written.

How stupid are you, Utkarsh?

The question arrived with an almost familiar cruelty.

How many times did you suspect it? How many times did you find yourself looking at the same things, asking the same questions, only to convince yourself that there might be another explanation?

He remembered the motorcycle.

Not the motorcycle itself, exactly, but the uneasiness that had followed his first suspicion about the boy beside it. A face, a name, a possibility that had seemed too uncertain to believe and too important to forget.

Then Bortir Bill.

He remembered asking Sanondita about the photographs. He remembered her mentioning Nayan. He remembered how quickly his curiosity had become something he struggled to conceal.

Is this guy your boyfriend?

He had asked her that once.

And she had answered that going somewhere with a boy did not necessarily make him her boyfriend.

He could hear the words now with an accuracy that embarrassed him.

Her answer had left the question open. He still did not know whether they had been together then.

But she had not said no.

He remembered noticing that.

He remembered how often he had returned to it, finding a different explanation whenever the last one became too painful.

You heard what she said, didn't you?

His fingers tightened slightly around his pen.

You heard what she didn't say.

He had spent the following days arguing with himself over the distinction. Perhaps she had simply disliked the assumption.

Perhaps she had thought the question foolish. Perhaps Nayan really was only a friend.

Each possibility had seemed reasonable enough when considered separately.

And whenever one began to trouble him, he had found comfort in another.

How easily he had done that.

He had treated uncertainty as though it were evidence in his favour.

He had mistaken the fact that she had never confirmed his fear for a reason to believe the fear was unfounded.

And all the while, life had continued beyond the classroom.

Sanondita had gone home. She had met people, spoken to them, made decisions, experienced things he would never hear about. Somewhere within that life, Nayan had become her boyfriend.

Utkarsh had not been there to see it happen.

Why should he have been?

The question was so obvious that it hurt.

He knew about her family, her students, her responsibilities, and some of the people she spent time with. He could remember the sound of her voice telling him those things. Now she had given him two answers, scarcely more than movements of her head, and he knew something he would have to carry home without knowing how to speak of it.

Yet he had behaved, privately and without quite admitting it, as though knowing more about her would eventually bring him nearer to something he could not name.

What exactly were you waiting for, Utkarsh?

He looked down at his notebook.

For her to tell you there was no one? For her to discover something about you that you had never dared to tell her yourself?

He could not answer.

The teacher said something about the next question. Several students began turning their pages.

Utkarsh turned his too.

He had no idea which question they were discussing.

His mind returned to the birthday photographs.

He remembered seeing Sanondita somewhere he had not been, celebrating with people whose place in her life he did not fully understand. He remembered the private theatre, the restaurant, the questions that had formed before he could stop them.

And he remembered the gift.

The perfume. The bamboo box. The note he had written after spending far too long deciding what words might say something without saying it plainly.

Your presence alone would make the angels question their own perfection.

He had given her those words.

He had waited afterward, wondering whether she would mention them.

She had thanked him for the gift.

And he had been happy.

Even now, he remembered that happiness clearly enough to feel embarrassed by it.

Did you think she would read your note and understand everything?

His gaze remained fixed on the page.

And if she had understood, what then? What did you expect her to do with a feeling you were too frightened to acknowledge?

He had never considered that question fairly.

He had wanted her to know without requiring him to tell her. He had wanted the safety of friendship and the possibility of something beyond it. He had wanted to remain close enough to hope, but far enough away that no answer could take the hope from him.

How carefully he had arranged his own uncertainty.

How terribly he had depended upon it.

You weren't waiting for the right moment, were you?

The thought unsettled him.

He had always believed there would be a better time. A day when they knew each other a little more. A conversation that would make his feelings easier to express. Some small indication that he would not be placing an unwanted burden upon her.

And there had been reasons to wait. Real ones. He had valued her friendship. He had respected the privacy of a life she did not owe him. He had feared making their familiar mornings uncomfortable.

But beneath those reasons lay another truth he could no longer avoid.

You were afraid that if you asked, she might answer.

He stopped moving his pen.

There it was.

For months, he had believed that the difficulty lay in finding the courage to confess.

Perhaps the greater difficulty had been accepting that confession would bring an answer he could neither choose nor postpone.

She might have said no.

She might have told him about Nayan.

She might have looked at him with surprise, or sadness, or the discomfort of someone who had suddenly discovered that a familiar friendship meant something different to the person beside her.

And then he would have had to return to the same classroom and learn how to sit beside her without expecting anything more.

He had not known whether he could do that.

So he had said nothing.

He had made jokes. Asked questions. Remembered her answers. Waited for her when she was absent, and tried not to appear too pleased when she returned.

He had called it patience.

Sometimes it had been patience.

Sometimes it had been respect.

And sometimes, he realised now, it had simply been fear wearing a more respectable name.

How foolish you have been.

He wanted to disagree with himself.

After all, what could he have done differently? He could not have prevented Sanondita from loving someone else. He could not have made himself more important to her by confessing earlier. He could not have turned every kindness into a promise merely because he had wished for one.

He knew all of that.

But knowledge was doing very little to comfort him.

He glanced towards her again.

She was still resting her head on the desk.

Only minutes earlier, he had thought she might be suffering from a migraine.

He wished, with a sudden and terrible shame, that he had never asked what was wrong.

Then he looked at her untidy hair, at the exhaustion in the way she held herself, and regretted even that thought.

She was unhappy.

Whatever had happened between her and Nayan had brought her to class looking unlike herself. He could see that much. He did not know the reason, and he would not ask.

Yet he was sitting beside her wishing he could return to a moment before he knew.

How selfish.

He looked away.

She is hurting, Utkarsh. And all you can think about is what her answer has done to you.

He tried to listen to the lesson.

For several seconds, he managed to follow the teacher's voice.

Then another thought interrupted.

He had been right about Nayan.

But being right had not prepared him for anything.

It had only taught him how much of his hope had depended upon being wrong.

He lowered his eyes to the notebook, where the question he had begun solving remained unfinished.

He could still remember the relief he used to feel whenever Sanondita arrived and took the place beside him.

He wondered whether she had ever felt that same lift in the morning when he arrived. He knew she had been glad to see him. What he could no longer bear was how much he needed to know about the gladness.

And for the first time that morning, the question of Nayan seemed almost smaller than the question of himself.

Someone behind him asked the teacher to repeat a question.

The teacher obliged. There was a brief sound of pages turning, followed by the familiar silence of students trying to understand something they had apparently understood a moment earlier.

Utkarsh looked at the door.

He did not know why.

It stood half-open, admitting a narrow strip of light from the corridor. Someone passed outside, and for an instant a shadow moved across the floor.

Just over a year earlier, Sanondita had come through a classroom door much like that one.

He remembered looking up.

It was strange how clearly he remembered looking up.

There had been nothing extraordinary about the occasion itself. A young woman had entered a coaching class. She had found a place to sit. The lesson had continued. No one had announced that anything important was beginning.

Certainly, she had not.

Yet he could remember the moment with a clarity that made the rest of that morning seem almost deliberately blurred.

He had wanted to know her name.

Such a small beginning.

A name.

He had already spoken to her that first morning, answering a question about Arithmetic before he knew what to call her. Learning her name came later. By then he wanted another reason to speak, something that would make their brief exchange the beginning of a conversation he could return to.

How little it took to make you happy, Utkarsh.

He remembered the awkwardness of those early days. The questions he had considered asking and abandoned. The occasions on which he had arrived at coaching with something prepared to say, only to discover that the moment was wrong, or that someone else was speaking to her, or that his courage had deserted him for no reason he could explain.

He had spoken to other people without difficulty.

He could argue, tease, make a ridiculous observation in front of half the class without giving it a second thought.

But with Sanondita, even an ordinary sentence had seemed to require preparation.

Why?

He had asked himself that question before.

Now it returned without offering him the familiar kindness of an easy answer.

What was so frightening about speaking to her? She was a person, Utkarsh. A person sitting in the same classroom, trying to understand the same lessons. Why did you behave as though asking her a question required a courage you did not possess?

He knew the answer, or part of it.

With other people, a failed conversation ended when the conversation ended. He might say something foolish, receive a foolish reply, and forget the whole exchange before reaching home.

With Sanondita, he had feared remembering.

He had feared an indifferent answer, a puzzled expression, the possibility that she might find him tiresome. He had feared that a moment of embarrassment would follow him into the next morning, and the morning after that, until the simple act of sitting near her became difficult.

Before he had even known her properly, he had begun to care what she thought of him.

And because he cared, he had made himself cautious.

Because he was cautious, he had taken longer to know her.

And because he had taken longer, every small step towards familiarity had seemed like an achievement.

How foolishly you measured your happiness.

He thought of the afternoon he had pretended to forget his phone.

How absurdly pleased he had been with that little invention.

He could still remember the relief of having a reason to look at the same PDF, the extraordinary importance he had attached to an arrangement that, to anyone watching, would have seemed perfectly ordinary.

Two students sharing a phone.

Nothing more.

He had not forgotten his own phone. He had simply wanted an excuse that would spare him the embarrassment of admitting why he wished to sit closer.

And it had worked.

She had helped him.

They had spoken.

He had obtained her number.

He remembered going home afterward with the ridiculous satisfaction of someone who had accomplished something difficult.

Difficult?

The word almost offended him now.

You asked a girl for help with a PDF, Utkarsh. You behaved as though you had crossed a mountain.

But the memory resisted his contempt.

He could still feel how nervous he had been. He could remember the effort it had taken to speak naturally, to avoid appearing too eager, to make the entire thing seem as unimportant as it ought to have been.

And he remembered how happy he had felt afterward.

He could call himself foolish now. He could look back upon that afternoon with all the cruelty of someone who knew how the story would disappoint him.

But he could not make the happiness false.

It had happened.

He had been happy.

The recognition troubled him more than the embarrassment.

For if those moments had been real, what exactly had the morning's revelation taken from them?

Sanondita had shared her phone with him. She had spoken to him. She had allowed a friendship to develop in the ordinary way friendships did.

None of that had been a promise.

None of it had been a lie.

Yet he had carried those moments forward, adding one to another, until they seemed to form the beginning of something neither of them had ever named.

Or rather, something he had never dared to name.

He remembered how much easier it had eventually become to speak to her.

There had been a time when he had searched for an excuse to ask a single question. Later, he could turn towards her without rehearsing anything. He could complain about a lesson, make an absurd remark, ask what she thought about something entirely unrelated to coaching.

Sometimes she would answer with such natural ease that he forgot how impossible that ease had once seemed.

He had mistaken the disappearance of his nervousness for the arrival of something more.

Not always. Not entirely.

He had known they were friends.

But he had begun to imagine that becoming familiar to her meant becoming important to her in the same way she was becoming important to him.

And why should it have meant that?

He looked towards Sanondita.

He had treated uncertainty as though it were evidence in his favour.

Of course he hadn't.

What would he have said?

That he had once struggled to ask her an ordinary question? That he had gone home delighted because she had laughed at something he said? That there were mornings when seeing her in the classroom had seemed sufficient reason to feel grateful for the day?

He imagined her listening.

He could not imagine what she would have done with such information.

Perhaps she would have laughed, believing he was exaggerating for amusement. Perhaps she would have been surprised. Perhaps she would have grown uncomfortable, wondering whether the friendship she had offered so freely had been misunderstood from the beginning.

He had kept his feelings to himself. In time, she had become accustomed to the version of him who could turn towards her easily: the talkative one, the boy who always found something ridiculous to say.

He could remember preparing those early conversations. Now the ease was real; he had not been pretending every time he laughed. But it had become a place to hide as well. She could know him well enough to recognise his jokes without knowing what made a silence like this so difficult.

He looked at her folded arms. Ordinarily he would have said something by now. She had only to lift her head and he would have to find that familiar voice again.

The teacher called out a number. Several students began working through a problem.

Utkarsh lowered his eyes to the notebook before him.

A year earlier, he had wanted to become someone Sanondita would recognise when he entered the classroom.

He had succeeded.

She knew his name. She knew his voice. She knew his jokes, his handwriting, his occasional carelessness with time. She could speak to him without hesitation. She could wait for him, complain to him, ask him questions, and make room beside her as naturally as she might have done for any familiar friend.

He had once wanted nothing more than that.

Then why does it feel like so little now?

The thought shamed him.

It wasn't little.

He knew it wasn't.

There had been a time when he would have given anything for the ease they now shared.

But he had changed the measure of his happiness without noticing. Each thing he received had become something he was grateful for, until gratitude quietly made room for the hope of something else.

And the hope had grown.

Not because Sanondita had asked it to.

Because he had allowed it to.

He had once been afraid that she would never know his name. She knew it now. She used it without hesitation, sometimes to call him back, sometimes to tell him to stop talking.

He tried to imagine hearing it that morning and answering as he always did. The thought tightened his throat.

The friendship had not disappeared. It was still there beside him, asking nothing different of him, while he struggled to understand what he had privately expected it to become.

He had counted the days between conversations.

Perhaps she had simply enjoyed the conversations.

He had remembered the first time she spoke his name.

Perhaps she had never thought of it as a first time at all.

He had taken home the happiness of being recognised.

Perhaps, to her, recognising him had never required a second thought.

And how could he resent her for that?

He could not.

He could only sit beside her and remember the young man who had once been afraid she would never know his name.

You were so frightened of remaining a stranger to her.

His eyes returned to the classroom door.

You never thought to ask whether becoming familiar was the same as becoming dear.

The teacher began explaining the solution.

Utkarsh picked up his pen, though he had forgotten where to begin.

Beside him, Sanondita remained silent.

He had spent a year learning how to speak to her without fear.

And on the morning he finally understood how much he had never known, he found himself frightened of speaking again.

A faint sound of rain came to him.

There was no rain outside.

The classroom windows admitted the pale light of a March morning, and somewhere beyond them the city was going about its business beneath an ordinary sky. Yet for a moment Utkarsh could hear water striking the pavement, running along the edge of a road, falling against the fabric of an umbrella held between two people.

He remembered that afternoon.

He remembered it with an accuracy that seemed almost unkind.

The rain had begun while they were still at coaching and was falling heavily when they left. He had an umbrella, though he

had pretended otherwise, and when they began walking together, he had been absurdly conscious of the small distance between them.

He remembered the effort of holding the umbrella a little more towards her.

He remembered the dampness reaching his own shoulder.

And he remembered how little he had minded.

He had wanted the road to be longer.

That was all.

Not a confession. Not a promise. Not even another conversation, necessarily. Only a few more minutes in which the rain would give them a reason to remain close without either of them having to explain it.

At the time, a few more minutes had seemed such a small thing to want. He had not thought about how often he would return to them afterward, or how much they would be asked to hold.

He looked at Sanondita.

Her head remained lowered. He wondered whether she was listening to the lesson, whether the sound of the teacher's voice was reaching her at all.

He wondered whether she remembered the rain.

Perhaps she did. Perhaps it had been an amusing afternoon, a pleasant walk, something she might recall if someone mentioned it.

Perhaps she remembered nothing about the umbrella except that they had shared one.

He could not know.

What troubled him was how clearly he remembered everything.

The position of her shoulder beneath the umbrella. The road ahead. The moment he had realised that the station was drawing nearer and that the walk would soon end. The quiet disappointment of having to let her go, even though there had been nothing reasonable about wanting to keep her there.

He had been happy.

So completely, foolishly happy.

He had carried the memory home with his wet clothes and his umbrella, remembering the shelter they had shared even after he no longer needed it.

And what had she returned home with?

A memory, perhaps.

Or merely the knowledge that she had reached home without getting too wet.

He closed his eyes briefly.

Why must you do this to yourself?

The question did not sound quite as cruel as the others.

Why must you take something that was beautiful and ask it to prove that you were loved?

He opened his eyes.

The walk had happened. She had been beside him. They had spoken, and he had listened, and for those few minutes he had been happier than he knew how to admit.

Did the memory become less beautiful because she might not have remembered it in the same way?

He wanted to say no.

He could almost believe it.

But the answer would not settle.

He remembered letting her go near the station, then looking for her through the rain after she had gone. She could not have known he was still there. He had kept that part of the afternoon to himself.

She had walked home with someone she trusted. He had remained behind, wanting the walk back. Neither memory could tell him what she had felt, and he was tired of making her absent voice answer questions he had never asked.

He lowered his gaze.

What was he supposed to do with that difference?

He had never asked her to feel what he felt. He had never expected her to explain the meaning of every kindness. He had understood, at least in principle, that friendship could be precious without becoming love.

But principles were easier to maintain when they did not have to stand beside memories.

And he had so many memories.

The small arguments over questions neither of them particularly enjoyed. The occasions when she waited for him before class. The way she sometimes turned towards him before answering a teacher, as though checking whether he had understood. The laughter that followed his more ridiculous

remarks, often accompanied by a look suggesting that she ought not to encourage him.

He remembered her asking him questions.

He remembered the satisfaction of being useful.

And he remembered how often he had asked her opinion about things that had nothing to do with coaching.

A shirt.

A dress for his sister.

Small decisions, ordinary enough to be forgotten by the next morning.

He had not forgotten.

He had sometimes found himself standing before a shop window, considering something she had once said about a colour or a style. He had imagined what she might think of a choice he had made. Her opinion had become part of his own judgement without his noticing when it happened.

How strange, to give someone a place in decisions they did not even know they were helping to make.

Did you ever matter to her in that way?

He did not know.

Perhaps she had asked his opinion about something and remembered it later. Perhaps she had repeated one of his jokes to someone at home. Perhaps, on an afternoon when coaching was cancelled, she had thought of something she would tell him when they next met.

Perhaps.

He had begun to dislike the word.

It had protected him for months. Now it seemed to offer nothing but another way of remaining uncertain.

His thoughts returned to November.

The bamboo box had fitted the perfume only after he adjusted it. He remembered checking the lid, wanting it to open easily for her. He had spent so long making the gift ready to receive.

The sentence inside it had been another matter.

He had already remembered the words that morning. Now what returned was the fold in the paper, the way he had put it beside the bottle and left it there despite considering taking it out. He had known it said more than an ordinary birthday wish. He had relied on it saying less than a confession.

She had thanked him. He had read the message more than once.

If she had asked what he meant, he might have smiled and found a harmless explanation. He could almost hear himself doing it. The thought brought a brief, unbearable tenderness for the person who might have had to listen: Sanondita, trying to understand a gift whose meaning he wanted both to offer and to deny.

He had wanted to be discovered and concealed at once.

His pen rested motionless between his fingers.

He could not decide whether he regretted the note.

He remembered how sincerely he had written it. Whatever fear had surrounded the words, the feeling itself had been genuine.

He had meant them.

He still did.

Sometimes it had been patience. Sometimes it had been respect. He could no longer tell how much of it had been fear.

Then what exactly has changed?

He looked towards the board.

The teacher had reached another part of the solution.

Utkarsh had missed the steps between.

What had changed was not the past.

The rain had still fallen. She had still walked beside him. She had still laughed at his jokes and waited for him on certain mornings. She had still accepted his gift and thanked him.

Those moments belonged to both of them, whatever each had made of them afterward.

But he could no longer look towards them and imagine that they were quietly leading somewhere.

He had never been promised a destination.

He had simply kept walking.

He remembered the rainy afternoon again.

The umbrella tilted towards her. The dampness on his shoulder. The road becoming shorter with every step.

He had wanted a little more time.

Now, a little over five months later, he understood something he had not known how to express then.

He had not wanted the rain to stop.

He had wanted the walk to become a reason for another walk.

And another.

And another.

He had wanted ordinary afternoons to continue until, somehow, they became a life in which she was always there.

He had never said that to her.

He had scarcely said it to himself.

He could no longer find the same anger for himself. What came instead was grief.

For the boy who had stood beneath an umbrella believing that happiness could be extended simply by walking a little more slowly.

For the boy who had carried a small gift across a city and believed that courage could be folded into a note.

For the boy who had made himself ridiculous to hear her laugh, who had spent nights remembering conversations that lasted minutes, who had been so careful not to ask for too much that he had never asked for anything at all.

He wished he could tell that boy what he knew now.

Then he realised that he would not.

He would not take the umbrella from his hands.

He would not tell him to leave the gift behind.

He would not ask him to forget the afternoons that had made him happy.

He would only wish that, somewhere along the way, the boy had learned that another person's kindness could be treasured without being mistaken for a promise.

Beside him, Sanondita shifted slightly against her folded arms.

Utkarsh turned towards her.

He could not see her expression.

He wondered whether she was remembering Nayan.

The thought came without the familiar urge to investigate it.

For the first time, he did not want to know what had happened between them.

He did not want to know where they had gone, what they had said, what had brought them together, or what had finally driven them apart.

There was a whole history there, and he had no wish to enter it.

He had spent months trying to discover whether Nayan was part of her life.

Now he knew.

And knowing had made him painfully aware of how much of her life had never belonged to his understanding.

He looked down at his notebook.

The page remained unfinished.

He thought of the rain once more, and of how happy he had been to walk beside her.

Then, for the first time, he allowed himself to consider a possibility he had always avoided.

Perhaps the afternoon had been beautiful to her too.

Perhaps she had remembered it.

Perhaps she had valued his company more than he would ever know.

And perhaps none of that had anything to do with loving him.

He had spent so long fearing that the memories might mean nothing to her.

He had never considered how much it would hurt to understand that they might have meant something good, something genuine, and still not what they meant to him.

He looked towards the place where her hand rested beside her notebook.

There was so little distance between them.

He had once believed that, given enough time, such distances might disappear.

Now he understood that two people could walk beneath the same umbrella, share the same laughter, remember the same afternoon, and still be travelling towards entirely different lives.

Four hours.

That was approximately how long they spent together on the days they both attended coaching. Sometimes less, when she arrived late or left early. Sometimes nothing at all.

He looked at the clock. Its hands had moved since he last remembered looking, though he could not say how far. On a good morning he had always wanted them to move more slowly.

Then coaching would end, and the four hours would follow him home.

A remark she had made while looking at a question. Something she had said about a shirt. The expression on her face when she tried not to laugh and failed. He would remember these things while eating, or searching for a book, or lying awake after he ought to have been asleep.

They spoke outside class too. There were messages on his phone, replies he could still find, small exchanges that had begun after they went their separate ways. He could not erase those merely because the morning hurt. She had reached towards him in the ordinary ways a friend did.

But after a conversation ended, he often went on living inside it.

That was the part he could not show her.

He would come across something amusing and think of sending it, then spend longer deciding whether to do so than the joke deserved. He would read a reply and hear her voice. When the phone was quiet, he could still imagine the next morning clearly enough to feel pleased that it was coming.

Four hours were not enough for you, so you took the remaining twenty and filled them with her yourself.

He pressed his lips together. The thought was cruel in its neatness. There had been work, family, other friends; he had lived those hours too. Yet she kept returning in the spaces between them, until he could scarcely remember when waiting for the next conversation had become part of an ordinary day.

He wondered whether anything similar happened to her.

Perhaps she remembered him while doing something else. Perhaps a remark returned and made her smile. He had no way to know the frequency or weight of those moments. Her messages could tell him that she had thought to speak to him. They could not tell him what the silence afterward contained.

Had she ever waited for a morning because she knew he would be there?

He knew she had waited for him at coaching. He remembered those occasions clearly. But he was asking about the hours before she arrived, the part of a day no one beside her could see.

He could not ask her now.

Sanondita, when you go home, do I disappear?

The question formed before he could stop it. Then he remembered the messages and felt the unfairness of it. He did not disappear. He was her friend. Why was he trying to make that sound like nothing?

What he wanted to ask had no harmless wording. He wanted to know whether being away from him had ever altered a day for her as being away from her altered his.

Beside him, her head remained lowered.

And there had been Nayan.

Utkarsh looked towards the board. He had spent months giving that name a face, a history, an imagined ease he could not compete with. Now the comparison brought him no closer to her. Somewhere beyond these classrooms, she had loved someone. Whatever had happened, she was hurting enough to sit through a lesson like this.

He had wanted that relationship not to exist. He could not make its ending into something to welcome.

The thought did not arrive as a noble decision. He had no speech ready for himself, no explanation of what he would do in the months ahead. He only knew that her loss did not make him want to ask for a place newly left empty. Looking at her, he could not want that place in that way.

He would go on loving her. That frightened him more than any question about what to do next.

His pen slipped a little between his fingers. He adjusted his grip and looked at the line he had copied. Somewhere he had left out a number. He could see the gap without remembering what belonged there.

He thought of the hours when she had been absent and he had looked towards the door at every arrival. He had not told her how often he did it. She could have walked in on any of those mornings and found him bent over a notebook, apparently occupied with his own life.

Perhaps there were things she concealed just as easily.

He had no wish to search for them now. He wanted her to lift her head because she felt better, not because her face might offer him another answer.

Four hours.

He had counted what they shared and forgotten how much of each day remained beyond his sight. The hours were real; so was everything that happened after them. He could no longer use one to explain the other.

He looked down at his unfinished notebook.

For a year, he had been trying to become part of her life. He had never noticed how completely she had become part of his.

The teacher said something that made a few students laugh.

It was not particularly funny. Under ordinary circumstances, Utkarsh might have added a remark of his own, something unnecessary and faintly ridiculous, and the laughter would have lasted a little longer.

He knew that because he had done it countless times.

He had made a habit of finding amusement in the most unpromising places. A difficult question, an unexpected mistake, the teacher's occasional impatience—almost anything could become an excuse for a joke if Sanondita was beside him.

Sometimes she laughed immediately. Sometimes she gave him a disapproving look before laughing despite herself. And sometimes she told him to concentrate on the lesson, though he had never been entirely convinced that she meant it.

He had grown accustomed to that small exchange.

A remark. A look. A laugh.

He had never considered how much he depended upon it.

Now the other students' laughter faded, and Sanondita did not lift her head.

Utkarsh watched her for a moment.

He wondered whether she had heard the joke. Perhaps she had and simply found nothing amusing about it. Perhaps she was too occupied with her thoughts to notice anything happening around her.

Or perhaps she had come to coaching hoping that something familiar would distract her.

The possibility troubled him.

She had been absent often enough in recent months that her presence that morning could not be taken for granted. She might have stayed home. She might have decided that attending a lesson was preferable to sitting alone with whatever had happened.

Perhaps she had wanted to be among people.

Perhaps she had wanted to hear someone say something foolish.

Perhaps she had wanted, for a little while, to forget.

And here he was, sitting beside her in silence.

Say something, Utkarsh.

He looked towards the teacher.

Perhaps she came here hoping you would make her laugh. Perhaps she thought she could sit beside you and feel a little better. And now, when she might actually need you to say something, you cannot even find a sentence.

He tried.

He looked at the question on the board, searching for something he might ordinarily have found amusing. He thought

of the teacher's explanation, of the mistakes students sometimes made, of the sort of observation that would have earned him an exasperated glance from Sanondita.

Nothing came.

Or rather, several things came, but none of them seemed worth saying.

He imagined turning towards her with a joke.

He imagined her lifting her head.

What if she tried to smile merely to be polite? What if she found his interruption irritating? What if she wanted nothing more than to be left alone?

He did not know whether laughter would comfort her.

He did not even know whether she wanted company.

And he hated that, after a year of knowing her, he could still be so uncertain about what to do when she was unhappy.

You know how to make her laugh when she is already happy.

The thought came quietly.

Do you know how to help her when she isn't?

He lowered his eyes.

There had been so many mornings when his greatest concern was whether she would laugh at something he said. He had learned to recognise the expression that appeared just before she smiled, the brief hesitation when she tried not to encourage him, the way a serious conversation could suddenly become ridiculous because one of them had misunderstood the other.

He knew those things.

He knew how she sometimes preferred to listen rather than speak. He knew she could become impatient with a difficult question. He knew she worried about responsibilities beyond coaching and that there were days when tiredness followed her into the classroom.

But knowing a person's habits was not the same as knowing how to ease their pain.

He had never felt that distinction so sharply.

For a moment, he considered asking whether she wanted some water.

Then he hesitated. She had nodded when he first asked whether she was all right, before telling him what had happened. Now her face was turned away. He could not tell whether another question would comfort her or merely make her lift her head again.

She had not asked him to continue questioning her. She had not explained what had happened. She had offered only enough of the truth to answer what he had asked.

Perhaps that was all she wished to offer.

There was nothing shameful in silence when another person did not wish to speak.

Yet his own silence did not feel entirely generous.

He knew why.

It was not only concern for her that kept him from speaking.

He was hurt.

He had been hurt from the moment she nodded at Nayan's name, and he had spent the minutes since then trying to examine

the hurt from every possible direction, as though understanding it might make it easier to bear.

He had followed one memory into another until the room seemed to recede around them. Each time he returned to her, she was still in the same position. He had been moving through a year; she had scarcely moved at all.

The contrast made him ashamed. He had almost forgotten how strange it was to be absorbed in his own loss while she sat beside him with hers.

Almost.

He looked at her again.

Her hair had shifted slightly. One hand rested near her face, the other beneath her folded arms.

He wanted to ask whether she was all right.

He had already asked.

He wanted to tell her that things would become easier.

He had no way of knowing whether they would.

He wanted to say that she deserved happiness.

The words seemed too large, too solemn, and too inadequate for the small classroom in which they sat.

Above all, he wanted to be the person who could make this morning less painful for her.

And he could not.

What good is loving someone if you cannot even comfort her?

The question struck him with such force that he almost accepted it.

He wanted to help her. He did not know how.

His hands stayed on the notebook.

Perhaps that, too, was part of caring: having no answer and staying anyway.

He wished he could set his own feelings aside for an hour.

He wished he could become the familiar, ridiculous Utkarsh she knew, the one who would find something absurd in an ordinary lesson and make her forget, even briefly, that she was unhappy.

He had done it so easily before.

Why was it impossible now?

Because he knew.

Because she had answered.

Because the person he had spent months trying not to imagine had become real in a single word, and the knowledge was still moving through him, touching memories he had thought were safe.

He could not pretend otherwise.

He could not simply decide that the revelation meant nothing to him.

And he could not ask Sanondita to understand why it meant so much.

She had come to class with her own sadness. Whatever had happened between her and Nayan belonged to her experience, her memories, her private disappointment.

She did not know that the boy sitting beside her had just suffered a different loss.

How could she?

He had never told her what he felt.

She knew the friend who made jokes, asked unnecessary questions, and sometimes looked at her a little longer than he intended.

She did not know the boy who had returned home after the rainy walk wishing it had lasted another hour.

She did not know the boy who had rehearsed ordinary conversations before speaking to her.

She did not know how carefully he had chosen the words inside her birthday gift, or how often he had wondered whether she had understood them.

She could not know that her answer about Nayan had reached a place in him he had spent a year concealing.

And he would not make her responsible for it.

He looked towards the board.

The teacher was explaining a calculation. Several students were copying the solution, their pens moving with the quiet urgency of people who feared the next line would appear before they had finished the previous one.

Utkarsh picked up his pen.

He tried to write.

His hand moved across the page, copying a few numbers whose meaning he could not follow.

Beside him, Sanondita remained still.

He thought again of making her laugh.

Perhaps later, if she lifted her head. Perhaps if she spoke first. Perhaps if an ordinary moment presented itself and he could respond without forcing cheerfulness upon her.

He would not turn her sadness into an opportunity to prove his importance.

He would not insist upon being useful merely because helplessness was difficult to bear.

For now, he could do nothing more than remain beside her.

But even that simple decision brought another wave of shame.

He was sitting beside someone he loved, someone who was unhappy, and a part of him wanted permission to think about his own pain.

Just for a little while.

Not because hers mattered less.

Not because he believed his disappointment was greater than the grief of losing someone she had actually loved.

But because he could not keep pretending that his heart had remained untouched by what she had told him.

He lowered his head slightly.

I am sorry, Sanondita.

The words formed with a tenderness that made his throat tighten.

I wish I knew how to make this morning easier for you. I wish I could be the person who makes you laugh without having to think about it. I wish I could set aside everything I have just learned and be the friend you know.

He paused.

But I cannot. Not yet.

He looked at the unfinished calculation.

I am sorry, Sanondita. For now, let me be a little selfish. Just for now.

He did not say the words aloud.

He did not turn towards her.

He allowed himself the silence he had been condemning.

And for the first time since she had answered his question, he stopped demanding that his pain justify itself.

He had loved her quietly.

He had hoped quietly.

Now he was hurting quietly too.

That was not something she had done wrong.

It was not something he had chosen.

He kept his pen against the page until he could loosen his grip. He could be quiet without deciding whether the quiet made him a good friend. For these few minutes, it was all he had.

The teacher moved on to another question.

Utkarsh followed the movement of the chalk.

The teacher moved to the next line of the calculation.

Utkarsh could still hear the chalk. He could not have repeated what it was writing.

He glanced towards Sanondita.

She was still there.

The distance between their shoulders had not changed. Their notebooks lay on the same desk. If someone had entered the classroom and looked at them, they might have seen nothing more than a tired girl resting her head and a boy concentrating poorly on a lesson.

He wanted to reach across that silence.

He wanted to tell her that he was sorry she was unhappy, that he wished things had been different for her, that he would have given anything to see her smile again.

The lesson continued.

Utkarsh had lost track of the question. On the board, the teacher was carrying a number from one line to the next; Utkarsh could see where it had gone, but not why. He looked down. He had copied the beginning of the solution and left the rest of the page blank.

Ordinarily he would have turned to Sanondita. If she understood the problem, she would explain it. If she did not, he could usually find something foolish to say about the two of them being equally hopeless.

He began to turn before he remembered.

She had not moved. One loose strand of hair lay against her cheek. He watched it for a moment, with the ridiculous impulse to tell her it was there. She would have brushed it aside. Perhaps she would have told him to pay attention to the board.

He faced forward again.

He had spent so many mornings wanting an excuse to speak to her. Now he had a dozen ordinary excuses and could use none of them.

The teacher rubbed out a line. Several students protested; they had not finished copying it. He paused, chalk in hand, while they caught up.

Utkarsh searched his notebook for the number he had missed. He found a space where it should have been, then another space below it. For a moment he could not remember which of the two he was trying to fill.

Beside him, Sanondita breathed quietly against her folded arms.

He wondered whether she had slept the night before. Whether someone at home knew. Whether there was a person she could speak to without beginning at the beginning. He hoped there was.

Then Nayan's name came back to him, not as a question this time, but as something settled.

For months he had wanted to be wrong about Nayan. Looking at her now, he wished the relationship had not ended like this. He had never meant to wish her unhappiness. Yet here she was, unhappy, and the fact that Nayan was no longer her boyfriend offered him nothing he could bear to call relief.

He tried to think of what he might say to her. Not about Nayan; she had told him all she wanted to tell. Something ordinary. Something that would make this morning a little less difficult.

He could not find it.

It was strange to have been so fluent in her company and to discover that the words he needed had never been among the ones he practised.

He glanced at the clock. There was still time left in the lesson. Afterward, they would gather their books. Someone would ask about homework. They would leave the classroom and go in their separate directions, as they had done so often that neither had ever needed to discuss it.

At home, someone might ask him how coaching had been.

He would probably say, Fine.

The answer seemed impossible and inevitable.

He looked at his hands. They were quite steady now. That troubled him more than he expected. He had imagined that a person would look different after hearing something like this. Yet his pen lay between his fingers as it always did. Nothing in the room required anyone to notice.

Sanondita shifted against her arms. He turned a little, then waited. She settled again without looking up.

He wanted her to look at him. The wish arrived so suddenly that he could not disguise it from himself. Just a glance; the beginning of the familiar expression that usually meant she had heard something ridiculous and was deciding whether to laugh.

Then he saw her lowered head and wished he had not wanted anything from her at all.

Enough, Utkarsh.

He looked down at the notebook. He had already asked her questions. She had answered. There was nothing else she owed him, not even the reassurance of an ordinary smile.

He remembered the rain: the weight of the umbrella in his hand, his damp shoulder, the road he had wanted to lengthen. He remembered the folded note inside the bamboo box. Both memories were still beautiful to him, which was almost harder than finding them spoiled.

For an instant he wanted to go back and warn himself. The boy under the umbrella would not have listened. Utkarsh was not certain he would have wanted him to.

The teacher began another calculation.

He copied its first number. His hand paused above the next line.

He wanted Sanondita to be happy again. That much he knew. He could not imagine what would make it happen, or when. He only knew that he would have given a great deal to see her lift her head without having to pretend.

He did not know what to do with the rest of his feelings. The shame, the tenderness, the small and stubborn hope he had not yet learned to stop having. They were all still there. Tomorrow they would probably be there too.

A student at the back asked the teacher to repeat the question.

The teacher repeated it.

Utkarsh raised his pen, ready to write, and realised he had missed the first number again.

He almost turned to Sanondita to ask what it was.

For a moment the old habit was stronger than everything he knew.

Then he saw her resting beside him, and let the question pass.

He left a space on the page where the number should have been.

The lesson went on.